

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Low

## WHY IT WORKS

People escalate or repeat themselves when they feel unheard — validation lowers this pressure. When someone knows their concern has been received, they become open to problem-solving rather than stuck on needing to be understood.

## WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not agreeing that the concern is correct — validating is receiving it, not conceding it.
- Not a stalling tactic before delivering the answer you already had.
- It is proving the concern arrived intact before you respond — so your response lands on open ears.

## THE PAYOFF

How it lands: I can bring them a problem and it will be taken seriously, not batted away.

Principle: People cannot hear your answer while they are still trying to make you hear their concern.

### What you gain

- De-escalation without concession
- Concerns raised early, while they are still cheap to fix
- Responses that land because they are targeted at the real worry
- Fewer repeated complaints — being heard once is usually enough
- Trust from clients and reports that survives bad news

### Why most people fail at it

- They hear the first sentence of the concern and start composing the rebuttal.
- Their validation is a formality: 'I hear you, BUT...'
- They answer the stated concern and miss the real one underneath.
- They validate and then never actually respond, which reads as evasion.

## CORE FORMULA

**Show you understood the concern -> Fully -> Before responding or defending**

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before addressing a concern, state it back in your own words to show you heard it. Then respond. Not before.

## BEST FOR

- Responding to criticism or complaint
- Managing someone who is upset or frustrated
- Negotiation and conflict situations
- Presenting solutions to resistant audiences

## METHOD, STEP BY STEP

### 1. Receive — Let the whole concern land

Hear it out without composing your reply. The discipline is internal: while they are talking, your only job is understanding, not rebuttal.

*Composing: (Nodding while mentally drafting the defence)*

*Receiving: 'Go on — I want the full version.'*

## 2. Reflect — Say it back in your own words

Paraphrase the concern and check the paraphrase. Getting it slightly wrong and being corrected is a feature — the correction is where the real concern lives.

*Parroting: 'So you are saying the deadline is a problem.'*

*Reflecting: 'So the worry is less the date, more that quality slips quietly to hit it. Right?'*

## 3. Respond — Answer the validated concern

Now respond — specifically, to the concern as confirmed. Validation without a real response is worse than none; it teaches people that being heard changes nothing.

*Generic: 'Anyway, I think it will be fine.'*

*Targeted: 'On the quality risk: we are adding a review gate at week two. That is the safeguard.'*

## FIELD TIP

### Validate the concern they meant, not the sentence they said.

Stated concerns are often proxies — 'the deadline worries me' can mean 'I do not want to be blamed'. Play back what you heard and ask if it is the core. The correction you get is the real concern.

*Situation: A report says the new process 'seems complicated'.*

*Don't: 'It is actually quite simple — look at the flowchart.'*

**Do: 'Complicated how — hard to learn, or risky when it goes wrong?'**

## PHRASE BANK

### Validation Phrases · Showing you understood

- "I understand why that would be a concern."
- "That is a reasonable worry to have."
- "I can see why that would land the way it did."
- "If I were in your position, I would have the same concern."
- "That is a real problem — I am not dismissing it."
- "I hear you — and I want to make sure I have understood it fully before I respond."
- "The concern makes sense given what you know."
- "I would be worried about that too."

### Full Understanding · Showing you got the whole concern

- "Just to make sure I have the full picture — is the concern about X, or also about Y?"
- "Tell me more about what is driving that worry."
- "What would make this worse, from your perspective?"
- "What would a good outcome look like for you here?"
- "I want to understand the concern fully before I try to address it."

### Stakeholder Validation · Clients, sponsors and senior audiences

- "You are right to press on this — it is the part of the plan with the most risk."
- "That question is exactly the one we asked ourselves. Here is where we landed."
- "If I were funding this, I would want the same reassurance."
- "The concern is legitimate, and it deserves a proper answer rather than a quick one."
- "Let me play the concern back to check I have it: you are worried that X. Is that the core?"

### Validation Under Fire · When they are angry, not just worried

- "You are angry, and given what happened, that is fair."
- "I am not going to defend this until I have properly heard it."
- "If that had happened to me, I would be in this office too."
- "Say the whole thing — I am not going anywhere."
- "This clearly is not a small thing to you, so I am not going to treat it like one."

### Bridge to Response · Moving from heard to answered

- "Now that I understand it, here is what I can do about it."
- "You have been heard — let me tell you what happens next."

- "That is the concern. Here is my answer to each part of it."
- "I have the full picture now. My response is this."
- "Given everything you have said, here is where I land."

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Jumping to defence: 'Well, actually the data shows...'  
Better: I understand the concern, but...  
**Best: That is a real concern — let me make sure I have understood it fully before I respond.**
2. Weak: Minimal validation: 'I hear you'  
Better: I understand that is frustrating.  
**Best: State the concern back in your own words, then add 'Is that right?' before responding.**
3. Weak: Validation followed immediately by dismissal  
Better: That is a valid point, but...  
**Best: Full validation, full pause, then a genuine response that takes the concern seriously.**

## DECISION TREE

### If Someone raises a concern before you have responded

Validate the concern before answering.

*"That concern is valid. Let me make sure I have understood it before I respond."*

### If You want to immediately defend or correct

Pause. Validate first. The defence will be more effective after.

*"I hear that — and I want to address it properly. Let me first make sure I understand it."*

### If The concern is partly invalid but contains truth

Validate the part that is valid. Do not dismiss the rest.

*"The underlying worry about X is real. The specific claim about Y is one I want to address."*

### If They do not feel heard even after you validated

Go deeper. Ask what you missed.

*"I want to make sure I got the full weight of the concern — what did I miss?"*

## SCENARIOS

### Client or stakeholder raises a concern about your work

Understand the concern fully before defending. — "I want to make sure I have the full picture of the concern before I respond to it."

### Direct report is frustrated about a decision

Validate the frustration before explaining the rationale. — "I can see why that decision landed badly. I want to hear the full impact before I explain it."

### Partner or friend raises a complaint

Show you understood before explaining your intentions. — "I hear that it landed that way. That is not how I meant it — and I also want to hear the full concern."

### Presenting a change to a resistant group

Open by naming their likely concern before pitching the solution. — "I know the first concern you will have is X. I want to address that directly."

## WORKED EXAMPLE

### Without the technique

Employee: I'm really worried about the deadline.

You: The deadline is fine — it's under control.

(Employee remains anxious and raises it again the next day)

### With the technique

You: That concern makes complete sense — this is a tight timeline and I'm taking it seriously. Here's where we stand and what I'm watching.

Employee: Knowing you're tracking it helps.

## COMMON MISTAKES

### The 'but' that deletes the validation

*Sounds like: 'That is a fair concern, but...'*

Better: 'That is a fair concern. Here is how I think about it.'

### Rebuttal-composing while they talk

*Sounds like: Interrupting with 'Right, but actually—'*

Better: 'Finish the thought — I want all of it before I respond.'

### Validating the surface, missing the core

*Sounds like: 'I know the timeline is tight.' (when they fear the blame, not the date)*

Better: 'Is the worry the date itself, or what happens to whoever misses it?'

### Validation as a stalling ritual

*Sounds like: 'I hear you, I really do...' followed by the pre-written answer*

Better: Let what they said visibly shape what you say next.

### Hearing without responding

*Sounds like: 'Thanks for raising that.' (end of scene)*

Better: 'You raised X. Here is what I am doing about it, and when.'

## READING THE ROOM

### Signs it is working

- People visibly relax after you validate.
- The conversation becomes less adversarial.
- Your responses land better because they are targeted.
- People feel heard even when the outcome does not change.

### Signs to adjust

- Validation sounds hollow — like a technique rather than genuine.
- You validate but then ignore the concern in your response.
- Validation is so long that the actual response gets lost.
- You are validating concerns you actually dismiss entirely.

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the concern is unfounded and validating it would reinforce a false belief.
- In situations requiring urgent action where pausing to validate delays a critical response.
- When someone is using the concern manipulatively to avoid accountability.

## RECOVERY LINES

**Best line: 'You have said this twice now, which tells me I did not really hear it the first time.'**

- "I jumped to defending before I had actually heard you. Start again?"
- "I answered the wrong worry. Tell me the real one once more."
- "That 'but' undid everything before it — let me say it without the but."
- "I have been talking you out of the concern instead of listening to it."
- "You have said this twice now, which tells me I did not really hear it the first time."
- "Let me check I have actually got it before I respond this time."

## TECHNIQUE CHAINS

### Objection chain

*Validate -> reflect back -> check the core -> answer that core*

You are right to push on the budget — it is the weakest part of the proposal.

The worry as I hear it: we commit, costs balloon, and there is no exit.

Is that the core of it?

Then here is the answer: staged funding with a kill-switch at month three.

### Upset-report chain

*Receive the heat -> validate the experience -> find the need -> commit to a step*

Say the whole thing — I am not going anywhere.

Given how the rollout landed on your team, the frustration is fair.

What would have made the difference — earlier warning, or more say in the plan?

Then from now on you see the plan before it ships. That is a commitment.

## RELATED TECHNIQUES

### TC016 — Validation Without Agreement

Validation Without Agreement is the harder sibling — for when you must validate a feeling while disputing the claim attached to it.

### TC010 — Curiosity Question

Curiosity Question supplies the probes that find the real concern under the stated one.

### TC004 — Repair Opening

Repair Opening applies when the concern is about you — and it arrived late because they did not feel safe raising it.

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

### Day 1 — Pause before defending

In one conversation today, notice the moment you feel the urge to defend before validating. Pause.

### Day 2 — State the concern back

In one conversation, state the other person's concern back in your own words before responding.

### Day 3 — Full validation

Validate a concern fully — without any 'but' or 'however' until you have completed the validation.

### Day 4 — Ask what you missed

After validating, ask: 'Is there more to the concern that I am missing?'

### Day 5 — Hard case

Validate a concern you genuinely disagree with or find unfair. Notice the effect.

### Day 6 — Pre-emptive validation

Open a presentation or conversation by naming the concern you expect they have, before they raise it.

### Day 7 — Calibration

Did validation change the tone of your conversations? Did people feel more heard? Did any feel hollow?

## AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I validate the concern before responding to it?
- Did I state the concern back accurately in my own words?
- Did I validate fully — without a 'but' or dismissal immediately after?
- Did my response actually take the concern seriously, not just acknowledge it?
- Did I ask if I had the full picture?
- Did I avoid validating as a technique to then ignore the concern?
- Did the other person seem to feel genuinely heard?